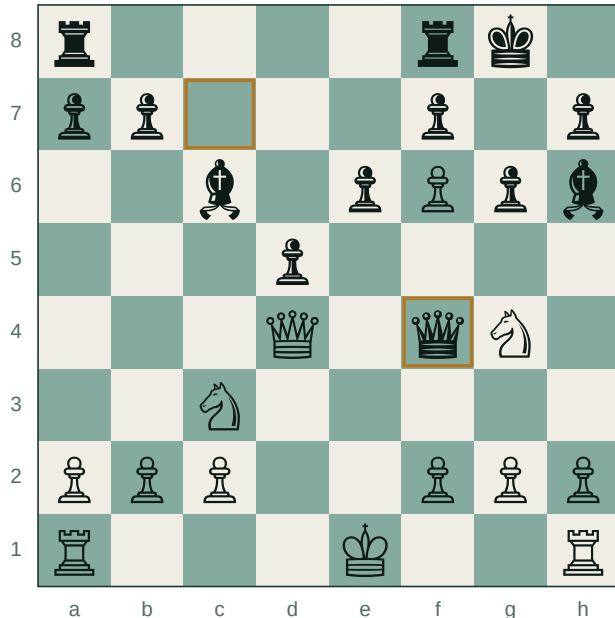


Intermediate moves: White, move 16

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 15...Qf4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16. Ne2 Qxd4 17. Nxh6+ Kh8 18. Nxd4

16.Ne2 The knight moves from c3 to e2. Recorded reply: **16...Qxd4**.

17.Nxh6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the bishop on h6. Recorded reply: **17...Kh8**.

18.Nxd4 The knight captures the queen on d4.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.